

the coupons entirely? These are the types of questions companies ask all the time.

The bottom line with all the time and money spent on shopper research and consumer studies is that companies want to know what people are buying and why. More importantly, they want to know how to get the consumer to buy more. There's a method to the madness of volume discounts ("Buy 10 for \$10"), and the secret lies in the perception of the shopper. Bargain appeals have been proven to work in getting the consumer to purchase more than they normally would because they perceive the price as a good deal, even when it isn't. The consumer reading this should remember: A bargain isn't always a bargain, and a "good deal" might just be a marketer's way of taking advantage of your perception as to what constitutes a deal. Remember my intention to purchase a coffeemaker and the subsequent detour to a "70% off" rack? Those two bags of clearance merchandise I left the store with were overpriced in the first place. It turns out that the "70% off" clearance price was comparable to the discount store's regular price on similar merchandise. Did I really get a good deal, or had I fallen for yet another sales ploy?

